As the world changes, it will naturally throw up new concepts and terminology. ‘Indo-Pacific’ is among the more recent additions to the global strategic lexicon. Because Donald Trump used this term in the 2017 APEC Summit and the US Pacific Command was renamed as the Indo-Pacific one, Americans think that they invented it. The Japanese, however, believe the credit should really go to them. After all, Prime Minister Shinzo Abe spoke at the Indian Parliament of the ‘Confluence of Two Oceans’ more than a decade ago. Indians themselves are not to be left behind, underlining that the Indo-Pacific has been tossed around in their naval thinking even earlier. And by establishing a dedicated division in its Foreign Ministry, India has signalled its attachment even more strongly. Australians too rank among the list of claimants, and the ASEAN led by Indonesia has now tabled an Indo-Pacific outlook. Purists may actually award it to a German strategist of the 1930s, Karl Haushofer, even though his perspective was that of a Eurasian strategist. But, whatever its analytics, Indo-Pacific today owes its existence primarily to the compulsions of practitioners. The waters are changing as we speak and Indo-Pacific is not tomorrow’s forecast but actually yesterday’s reality.

Many things in the world come around. It is worth reflecting on the fact that the Royal Navy acted on an Indo-Pacific approach for decades without necessarily articulating the term. So today, as some powers aspire, others plan, a few prepare and the rest ponder, what drives the debate needs a clarity divorced from claims of ownership. Semantics should not obscure the fact that events are unfolding that give this concept a greater texture with each passing day. The Indo-Pacific naturally means different things to different powers, but it undeniably is a priority for all of them. For India, it is the logical next step beyond Act East and a transcending of the confines of South Asia. For Japan, the movement into the Indian Ocean could be part of its strategic evolution. For the US, a unified theatre addresses convergences that are central to its new posture. Russia, for its part, could visualize this as part of its new emphasis on the Far East. For Europe, it is a case for a return to a region from which it withdrew. And the stakes are particularly high for China, as its maritime capabilities are the prerequisite to its emergence as a global power.